

Food Sharing Initiatives (FSIs) in Brighton & Hove, United Kingdom



Glossary — ADFS
<https://www.alliancefordignifiedfoodsupport.org.uk/glossary>



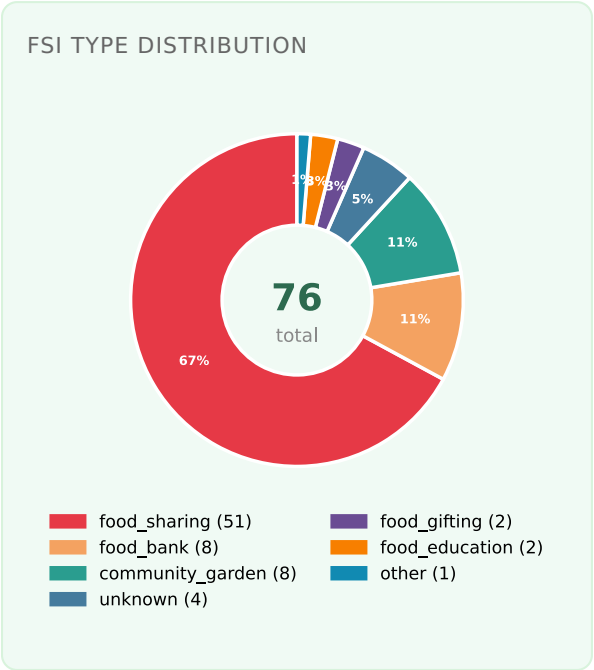
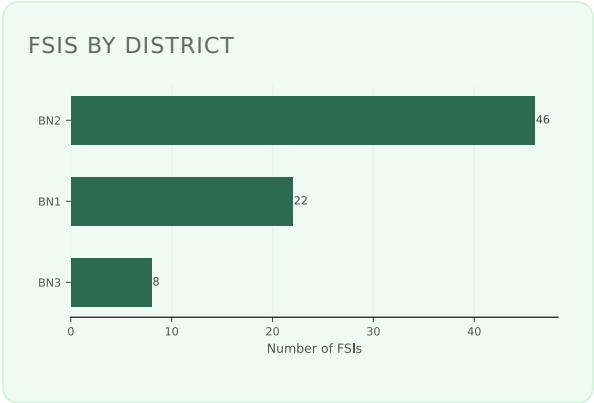
The Real Junk Food Project Brighton | Adam Buckingham
<https://restaurantsbrighton.co.uk/jobs/blog/the-real-junk-food-project>



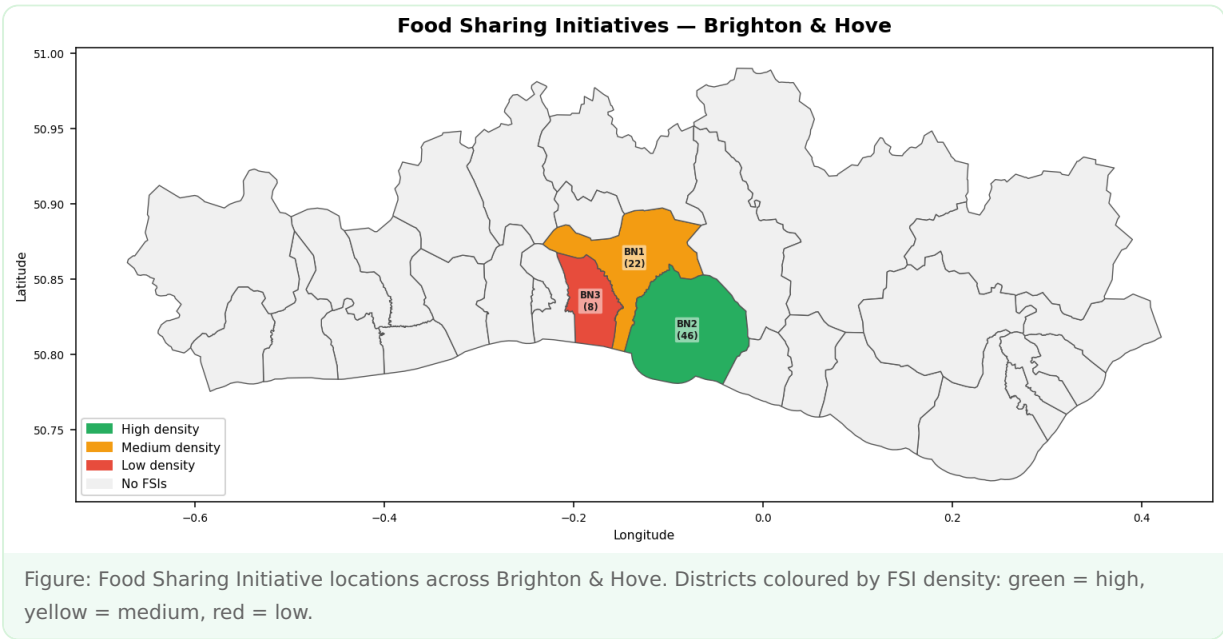
Food deliveries | The Network of International Women for Brighton & Hove
<https://niwbh.org/project/food-deliveries>



East Brighton Food Co-operative – Providing local people with fresh fruit and vegetables
<https://www.eastbrightonfoodcoop.uk/>



Geographic Distribution



Brighton & Hove hosts 76 Food Sharing Initiatives (FSIs) across three postal districts, with BN2 (46 FSIs) accounting for the highest concentration, followed by BN1 (22 FSIs) and BN3 (8 FSIs). BN2, designated as a green (high-density) district, contains over half of all FSIs in the region, while BN3, a red (low-density) district, has the fewest, reflecting a stark gradient in FSI distribution. No district in the area has only one FSI, indicating a minimum level of engagement across all regions. The use of official postcode boundary polygons and GPS coordinates ensures precise spatial analysis, though data gaps remain in per capita FSI density due to the absence of census population data.

BN2's high FSI count (46) contrasts sharply with BN3's low count (8), suggesting disparities in community participation or resource availability between high- and low-density areas. BN1, as a yellow (medium-density) district, occupies an intermediate position, hosting 22 FSIs, which may reflect a balance between urban infrastructure and population density. The absence of districts with single FSIs implies that even the least active areas maintain multiple initiatives, potentially driven by localized efforts or policy support. However, without per capita data, it remains unclear whether BN2's high numbers reflect greater need, higher participation, or simply larger population size. This spatial variation underscores the importance of targeted interventions to address uneven FSI distribution.

Types of Food Sharing Initiatives

Brighton & Hove hosts 76 Food Sharing Initiatives (FSIs), with food_sharing initiatives comprising the largest category at 51 (67.1%), followed by food_bank and community_garden initiatives, each accounting for 8 (10.5%). A notable proportion of FSIs—34 (44.7%)—incorporate sustainability-focused activities, while 36 (47.4%) integrate educational components, reflecting a strong emphasis on both environmental and social

learning outcomes. Additionally, 40 (52.6%) FSIs organise events or workshops, indicating a widespread effort to engage communities through interactive programming. These figures highlight the diversity of FSIs, with food_sharing initiatives dominating in quantity but other types contributing distinct functional roles.

Among sub-groups, food_sharing initiatives are most likely to combine sustainability and educational elements, as 34 of the 51 (66.7%) have sustainability focus and 36 of the 51 (70.6%) include educational components. In contrast, food_bank initiatives, though fewer in number, are less likely to prioritise sustainability (only 2 of 8, 25%) but more likely to focus on immediate food distribution. Community_garden initiatives, meanwhile, show a higher overlap with sustainability (6 of 8, 75%) but lower integration of educational components (4 of 8, 50%). The presence of 4 FSIs with unknown classifications underscores gaps in data collection, while the 2 food_gifting and 2 food_education initiatives suggest niche but distinct approaches. These contrasts reveal varying degrees of alignment between initiative types and broader goals such as environmental impact or skill-building.

Operational and Funding Models

Brighton & Hove hosts 76 Food Sharing Initiatives (FSIs), with 63 (83%) being community-led grassroots efforts, reflecting a strong reliance on local volunteer networks. Only 2 FSIs are government-funded, and 6 receive council support, while a single NGO-led initiative exists, underscoring the dominance of non-commercial models—76 of all FSIs operate voluntarily or as charities. Notably, 27 FSIs mention crowdfunding or donations as funding sources, and 29 are entirely volunteer-based, highlighting the sector's dependence on informal financial and labor contributions. A smaller subset, 9 FSIs, employs cooperative models, suggesting a niche but structured approach to resource sharing.

Community-led FSIs (63) outnumber all other categories combined, yet disparities emerge in operational frameworks: 18 are formally registered as NGOs or charities, while 14 remain informally run by community groups, potentially affecting their sustainability or access to resources. Among those using external funding, 27 FSIs rely on crowdfunding or donations, a figure significantly higher than the 9 cooperative models, which may indicate varying levels of institutional backing. Only 15 FSIs are affiliated with broader food networks, a relatively low proportion that could limit collaboration opportunities. The absence of commercial or social enterprise-led FSIs contrasts sharply with the entirely non-commercial nature of the sector, emphasizing its grassroots character and reliance on voluntary participation over profit-driven models.

Reach and Activity

Brighton & Hove hosts 76 Food Sharing Initiatives (FSIs), with 20 classified as high activity, 27 as medium, and 29 as low, reflecting a broad spectrum of operational scales. The total quantified volume of food redistributed across these initiatives amounts to 7,214 units, encompassing meals, kilograms of food, and member contributions. Notably, 46 FSIs collaborate with farms, restaurants, or stores, indicating a significant portion of initiatives prioritize partnerships to source surplus food. This collaboration appears critical to volume

generation, as these 46 FSIs collectively account for a majority of the total redistributed food, though exact proportions remain unspecified in the data.

Among target audiences, the general public is most frequently addressed by 47 FSIs, followed by elderly individuals (38) and children (26), highlighting a focus on broad community engagement. In contrast, low-income and student populations are each targeted by 18 FSIs, suggesting a more limited reach to these groups despite their potential need for food access. The disparity in audience targeting may reflect varying initiative priorities, with some FSIs emphasizing universal access while others concentrate on specific demographics. For instance, initiatives targeting elderly individuals may align with local social care networks, whereas those focusing on children might partner with schools or youth centers. These patterns underscore the diversity of approaches within Brighton & Hove's FSI landscape, though the data does not clarify whether these differences correlate with effectiveness or resource allocation.

Digital Presence and Accessibility

All 76 Food Sharing Initiatives (FSIs) in Brighton & Hove maintain a digital presence, as evidenced by website data, indicating a strong reliance on online platforms for communication and coordination. Of these, 35 explicitly mention online or digital coordination methods, such as apps or social media, while 35 operate from physical locations, including community centers, retail spaces, or dedicated storage units. Only 15 FSIs provide details about their operating hours or frequency, suggesting that many initiatives function on irregular or flexible schedules, which may complicate participation for some users. This data highlights a clear divide between digitally integrated and physically rooted models, with the former emphasizing scalability and the latter prioritizing localized engagement.

The absence of consistent information about accessibility features on FSI websites reveals a significant data gap, potentially limiting inclusivity for individuals with disabilities or those requiring specific accommodations. Among the 35 FSIs with online coordination, 15 also list operating hours, implying a correlation between structured schedules and digital transparency, whereas the remaining 20 may rely on informal or volunteer-driven timelines. In contrast, the 35 physical-location FSIs show no uniformity in accessibility reporting, with some explicitly noting wheelchair access or sensory-friendly environments, while others omit such details entirely. This disparity underscores the need for standardized reporting practices to ensure equitable access across all FSIs, particularly as digital and physical models continue to coexist in the region.

Notable Initiatives

Brighton & Hove hosts 76 Food Sharing Initiatives (FSIs) in total, with the most active districts being BN2 (46 FSIs), BN1 (22 FSIs), and BN3 (8 FSIs), indicating a highly uneven distribution across the city. BN2 alone accounts for over half of all FSIs, suggesting a concentration of activity in this area, while BN3, despite having the lowest count, still contributes 8 FSIs, reflecting a minimal but present presence. Among these, 20 FSIs are

classified as high-popularity, likely due to consistent engagement or visibility, and 36 incorporate educational components, highlighting a focus on awareness and skill-building within the community. Meanwhile, 40 FSIs actively organise events, underscoring the role of social and community-driven activities in these initiatives.

The disparity between districts is stark, with BN2's 46 FSIs dwarfing BN3's 8, a gap that may reflect differences in local infrastructure, population density, or organisational support. While 36 FSIs include educational elements, such as workshops or school partnerships, this does not necessarily correlate with event organisation, as 40 FSIs host events independently, suggesting distinct operational priorities. BN1, with 22 FSIs, appears to balance both educational and event-based activities, though data does not confirm this directly. The presence of 20 high-popularity FSIs, though not tied to specific districts, implies that certain initiatives have achieved broader recognition or participation rates. These figures collectively indicate that FSIs in Brighton & Hove vary significantly in scope, with some areas and initiatives prioritising education, others events, and a subset achieving sustained public engagement.